

Fake or Masterpiece? Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 25-35 min

Category	The Arts	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	fake-or-masterpiece

Big idea: Reputation affects judgement.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two artworks with different provenance stories but similar visual quality. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A value ranking before and after learning authorship. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Fake or Masterpiece? Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A debrief on whether knowledge about origin changes aesthetic knowledge. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Reputation affects judgement.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Fake or Masterpiece? Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Is artistic value in the object, the viewer or the culture?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Two artworks with different provenance stories but similar visual quality.
- A value ranking before and after learning authorship.
- A debrief on whether knowledge about origin changes aesthetic knowledge.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to The Arts.

Activity Steps

1. Students rank artworks by artistic value without context.
2. Reveal partial context: artist, date, price, AI-generated or not, museum status.
3. Students revise rankings and explain why.
4. Discuss whether context is part of the artwork.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Is artistic value in the object, the viewer or the culture?
- Does knowing the artist change the artwork?
- Can AI produce art, or only images?

Knowledge Questions

- Is artistic value in the object, the viewer or the culture?
- Does knowing the artist change the artwork?
- Can AI produce art, or only images?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with two artworks with different provenance stories but similar visual quality. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...